

Guidelines for Resume and Interviews

* as per the session given by Avanish Mundhra from Cantilever Labs on 10th and 13th August at IITB to students sitting for placements.

Resumes

1. The job of a Resume is to make the recruiter want to talk to the candidate. The recruiter has to be impressed.
2. A bad resume gets 5 seconds of attention, A good resume get 25 seconds.
3. A resume should either be 1 page long or 2 pages long. It should not be 1.5 pages long.
4. We should use bullet points in the resume.
5. Orphan Words are not allowed in each bullet point.
6. Calibri Font takes the gold, Times New Roman and Helvetica come second.
7. Non Core Resumes = 1 page long (Academic Balanced).
8. Core Resume = 2 page long (Academic Heavy).
9. The use of Bold = domain, company specific
10. Do not write sentences, write statements in the Resume
11. Framing of every statement, Representation of Information = Impact Word, What, How, Effect. OR. Impact Word, How, What, Effect.
Examples:-
 - a. **Automated** client notification process **using VBA** reducing 20 man hours per week for the company.
 - b. **Spearheaded** a team of 15 **working on a budget of 1 Million** to conduct 10 events throughout the year.
12. If you use LLMs to generate the resumes and the recruiter gets nothing, then your resume goes into the dustbin. Let the main point of your resume be at

the front. Let the recruiter be amazed. What & How you did it comes second, but tell me you moved a mountain. The impact should hit them.

13. If you have a list of friends and there is SRK, Elon Musk in it. Then their name should be at the top of your list. Nobody would find SRK somewhere in the middle of the list, his name should be at the top.
14. The Resume needs Numbers, Numbers, Numbers. Numbers ground things in reality. They make things believable.
15. If your rank in some big exam is < 500 . Then write it down, else do not write it. You can write percentile. Rank + Percentile is also great to write. Do not leave whitespaces.
16. Do not write your strengths or weaknesses. Nobody cares
17. No signing, no dates, no location.
18. Write down your hobbies and interests.
19. Core Resume = Internships, Projects, Certificates should be mentioned. 3 bullet points per item.
20. Non Core Resume = Soft Skills, PORs, Extra Curriculars, Area of Expertise. Every item should get 2 bullet points.
21. Questions to Expect = Tell me about Yourself. What is the headline of your life story?
22. If you don't have internships → Certificates.
23. If CGPA is less, then figure out a reason that you will tell the interview panel.
24. Prep using AI interviews + Expert interviews + Mock interviews
25. Single Column > Double Column. Things are easier to find in a Single Column Resume.
26. Do not keep your resume focused on one thing only. Add some variation, like adding a project of ML/DS in a SDE resume. 1/4 projects should be of some different role.
27. MTP = Write whatever you have achieved and all that you are going to achieve.

28. In a document that you post online. There should not be more than 2 hyperlinks. If there are more than 2 hyperlinks, it is considered spam. Use the 2 links for Github, Kaggle, LinkedIn etc.
29. 4 Projects = 1 pages
8 Projects = 2 pages
3/4 = related to that industry
1/4 = not related to that industry(to show diversity)
30. AI skills are a huge hit if you can write and display.
31. If a resume is good, 80% of questions come from the Resume. Else 20% of questions come from it.
32. **CR7 FRAMEWORK OF A COOL RESUME**
- a. Personal Information = Name, e-mail, phone, LinkedIn, Github.
Educational Qualification = Board, Percentage, Years
 - b. Internships = Company Name, Time, Designation, Work done explained in 3 bullet points.
 - c. Projects and Certifications = Name, Work Done explained
 - d. Area of Expertise = If you are an expert in something, mention that you are an expert in it. If you are a beginner in it, then do not mention Beginner in Python. Just mention Python
 - e. Positions of Responsibilities = Designation, Time, Role, Impact Information
 - f. Awards and Recognitions =
 - g. Hobbies and Interests = Please make sure you write this
33. Masters Students Resume Points(Off Campus)
- a. Scholastic Achievements = GATE, Scholarships, Olympiads, Exchange, Minors, UG Rank, AP Grade etc.
 - b. Publications = International Journal, Conferences Proceedings, Research Papers
 - c. Projects and Seminars = MTP, BTP, Course Projects, Club Projects

- d. Work Experience/Internship
- e. Position of Responsibility = Positions, TA, Student Mentor, College Bodies, Clubs, Activities/Events

34. Key Projects and Seminars

- a. Objective, Outcome, Impact of the work to be shown clearly
- b. Masters thesis project can include objective, what is done till now, future work and scope.
- c. B.Tech thesis project.
- d. Mini Projects (can include self projects)
- e. Course projects (helps in defining the breadth of exposure cover in 2 points)
- f. M.Tech Seminar
- g. Course Seminar (based on the relevance to the profile)

35. For School Information, write Board's name and not School's name.

36. Don't mention GRE/GMAT Score

37. CFA, FRM - Great to have

38. Good Organisations from where you can take courses = Bloomberg(10 hours course on Finance for Roles like Finance, Analytics, Consult, Business Dev, All), John Hopkins(Finance, Analytics), Stanford University, Google Data Analytics Professional Certificate(Data Science, Data Analytics)

39. How to write Project/Intership

Your Role/Designation | Name of the Company
Months

Name of the Company | Your role/Designation
Months

40.

More on Resume by Shailesh Mishra an alumni of IITB

1. The purpose of the Resume is to get you into the next stage.

2. A resume has to do 4 things:-
 - a. Relevance = Why are you suitable for this role?
 - b. Impact = What difference did you create?
 - c. Clarity = Can I understand your profile quickly?
 - i. Things should be in an order.
 - d. Evidence = Can you prove what you are claiming?
3. The recruiter is asking, "Is this profile relevant enough for me to spend 30 more minutes interviewing this person?"
4. You don't have one profile. You have multiple stories within the same profile.
5. One Master profile can be tuned to fit different roles.
 - a. Consulting
 - b. Analytics
 - c. Product
 - d. Operations/PM
 - e. Core/Technical
6. Same Project: **Built a predictive model for manufacturing defects.**
 It can be used for
 - a. analytics = Developed ML model → accuracy → features → data size
 - b. consulting = Identified operational drivers → analysed process → recommended intervention → business impact
 - c. product = Identified user/ process pain point → designed solution → adaptoin/ outcome
7. The underlying achievements remain the same. The emphasis changes.
8. Do not add a section because everyone has it. Add it because it strengthens your case!
9. Do not forge projects. If you get caught in the interview, you'll get rejected.
10. Experience = Do not describe your job. Sell your impact.

- a. Weak = Responsible for managing social media campaigns.
- b. Better = Managed social media campaigns across multiple platforms.
- c. Strong = Managed multi-platform campaigns, increasing engagements by 42% across 3 months.

11. Strong Structure to talk about Experience:-

- a. Action + What + How + Scale + Result
- b. Bullet Formula: Strong Verb + Problem/ Task + Method + Scale + Measurable Impact

12. Action Verbs = Analyzed, Optimized, Automated, Designed, Launched, Delivered, Developed, Streamlined.

13. Avoid = Worked on, Helped, Assisted, Responsible for, Involved in, Participated in

14. Every project is boring until you find the story. Students often write = Analysis of X using Y. Instead focus every project line.

- a. S → Situation. What was the problem/context?
- b. T → Task. What were you responsible for?
- c. A → Action. What exactly did you do? How?
- d. R → Result. What changed because of your action?
- e. Scale | Complexity | Method | Comparison | Insight | Innovation | Outcome

15. Before: Worked on improving the company's customer complaint process.
STAR Thinking:

- a. S = High Complaint resolution time
- b. T = Improve resolution process
- c. A = Analyzed 10,000+ complaints and identified recurring bottlenecks.
- d. R = Reduced average resolution time by 25%
- e. Resume bullets = Analyzed 10,000+ customer complaints to identify recurring resolution bottlenecks, redesigning the workflow to reduce

average resolution time by 25%.

16. Projects: How many and which ones?

- a. More projects $\neq$ Stronger Profile
- b. Choose Projects based on Relevance x Quality x Differentiation
- c. If you do not have work ex. Projects become much more important.
- d. Workex > Highly relevant Projects > Supporting Projects
- e. Every project should earn its space. The resume should be impactful. Otherwise, skip that project.
- f. Just because you have made a project, does not mean it should be on the resume.

17. What if I do not have enough to put on my resume

- a. You do not need a strong resume. You need strong evidence.
- b. No internship $\neq$ No experience.
- c. What evidence do i have that demonstrates the skills this role needs?
- d. You may have:
 - i. Academic Project
 - ii. Research
 - iii. Course Projects
 - iv. Competitions
 - v. PORs
 - vi. Freelance Work
 - vii. Teaching
 - viii. Open Source
 - ix. Personal Projects
 - x. Entrepreneurship
 - xi. Social Media / Youtube

xii. Volunteering

18. Don't Write the Title. Show the Ownership!

- a. POR Bullet Structure: Role → Scale → Initiative → Stakeholders → Outcome
- b. For leadership experience ask:
 - i. What did you own?
 - ii. How many people were involved?
 - iii. Who did you influence?
 - iv. What problem did you solve?
 - v. What changed because of you?
- c. They hire you because your POR demonstrates:

19. Your resume should read like a story, not a scrapbook.

- a. The Why You test: After reading the resume, the recruiter should subconsciously be able to answer. "Why should I interview this person for this role?"
- b. Don't optimise every section independent.

20. Every resume has limited space. Resume Items:

- a. National level competition
- b. Machine Learning Project
- c. Youtube Channel
- d. College Event Organizer
- e. Sales Internship

21. You get 7 seconds to get your resume to show yourself.

22. ATS is not your enemy. A badly structured resume is.

- a. ATS = Applicant Tracking System. It may help organization. Receive → Parse → Search → Filter → Rank/Review Applications
- b. ATS-Friendly Principles

- c. Use: Std. section headings
- d. Clean text structure
- e. Role relevant keywords
- f. Consistent formatting
- g. Normal fonts
- h. Clearly written skills
- i. Correct job terminology

Avoid:

- a. Excessive Graphics
- b. Text inside images
- c. Complicated tables
- d. Decorative icons replacing text
- e. Unnecessary columns
- f. Hidden keywords
- g. Keyword stuffing

There is no universal ATS formula!

23. Ask AI to write your resume. Ask AI to attack your resume.
 - a. Diagnose = Where is this resume weak?
 - b. Match = How well does this resume match this JD?
 - c. Make this bullet sharper without changing facts.
 - d. Detect Errors = grammar, tense, duplication, inconsistency, formatting, unsupported claims.

Interview Preparation

Hedging should not become Confusion.

FRAMEWORK 1 = PLAYING 11

1. There are 11 most important questions for an interview.

- a. Name of the Company.
 - b. Company's Core Business = What does Google do. Don't give a one word answer. A story, a personal connect. What makes this company special and unique. Impress them. Something they do not expect.
 - c. HQ Location, India Branch, CEO Name
 - d. Job Role = Typical Day at the Office, Be realistic, expand the answer.
2. Career Progression in the company = SDE 1, SDE 2, SDE 3, National/International Position, the timeline of these roles = You may want to point out during the interview that you acquired this information by reaching out to people who are already working in the company. Show them, you are serious.
Show them you are in it, for the next 10 years. Because you know where you would be in the company after 10 years. Because you took initiative and reached out to everyone in the company.
 3. Connect with people from the company on LinkedIn
 4. Playing 11 = Make it for all the companies. On the day of the interview something like 30 seconds can help you answer 3/20 questions that will be from the Playing 11. High ROI Section

FRAMEWORK 2 = BREADCRUMBS

1. Tell me about Yourself? They will ask you this. Prepare for this question.
Answer this question in such a manner that you sprinkle breadcrumbs in the answer. The recruiter should pick them up and ask you questions from them. You prime the recruiter this way to ask you what you are prepared for. They ask you known questions.
2. Find 4, 5 non-technical questions that leave high probability to appear in your interviews. Give your mock interviews. Purpose of mock interviews is to refine the breadcrumbs. The breadcrumbs have to be so compelling that the interviewer is compelled to ask you questions related to them.
3. The first thing that gets you rejected in an interview is Non Compliance, Dishonesty. Recruiters talk to each other. The fact that you lied would spread. Do not get caught lying!!

FRAMEWORK 3 = TEN 10

Content >> Language

Consulting, Product Management care about language.

10 Questions of the interview, you already know.

- What if we do not select you?
 - I will be disappointed. Your company is my dream company. But, I will get a job in the placements.
- What do you know about the company?

Guesstimation and Case Studied can come for any role especially non-core roles.

FRAMEWORK 4 = SERIAL POSITION EFFECT

First and the last part of the interview should be the best. If the recruiter remembers you, you are in, else you are out. Start Well = Playing 11. End Very Very well = Ask a question.

In the middle part, use breadcrumbs and ten 10.

Ask a question from the recruiter.

1. If some question of yours was not solved, ask permission to take another shot at it. This shows recall under pressure. Rectification ability.
2. Ask about the company if there is time.
3. Ask them about themselves.
4. Ask them how they prepared for the interview. Recruiters at IITB also prepare for the interviews.
5. Interest and Hobbies = Company Culture. Very Very Important. Many Questions can come from it. It gives a view into the real you. Everyone knows that the Resume achievements are exaggerated.

FRAMEWORK 5 = 22 YARDS

HR Round = English Speaking Contest

If you have cleared technical, do not fall here.

Clarity of thought, mind.

Strength, Weaknesses. Many variations of the same questions can come.

Practice Mock interviews.

A good resume = half the job done.

Q&A Session

1. 7.8 CGPA is very very good.(The guy who asked this question was from Non-CS branch).
2. Self Project made using Claude = You can put it there. Prepare for it. The first filter is getting it past the Placement Team.
3. People go to higher studies for 2 reasons. They want a breakthrough in their company or in their compensation. So, if they ask you, would you go for higher studies. Tell them that you are inherently not interested in it, but if these two things happen, then you will be forced to. So, now it is in their hands.
4. B.Tech Projects should come last. First comes M.Tech Projects. If you do not have enough M.Tech projects, then add it there.
5. Do not make jokes there. You should however, be WITTY. Humour is good for making connection.
6. Night before the interview. Do mock interviews(AI), 3-4. AI Mock(No looking at assesment, just as a warmup).
7. Mock Interviews are not necessarily done for assesment, it is done for Failures. Make a 1000 mistakes before the Interviews, so that you do not make them in front of the interview panel.